

Crossing Runways Separation Interpretation (U.S. Air Traffic Control)

Seed Log (Retrospective Seed – SL-002)

Timeframe; Recorded: Spring 2025; March 2026

Revision Note: Formatting and timeframe standardization updated (Version 1.1)

Observation: Two Certified Professional Controllers (CPCs) held different interpretations of the crossing runway separation standard for aircraft operating under instrument flight rules (IFR) in instrument meteorological conditions (IMC), specifically between an arrival and a departure.

Trigger: A supervisor filed a Mandatory Occurrence Report (MOR) alleging a separation error during crossing runway operations involving the two IFR aircraft.

V.A.I.Y.L. Sequence

Variation

One CPC interpreted that crossing runway separation standards could only be applied when the field was in visual meteorological conditions (VMC) or when tower-applied visual separation had been coordinated in accordance with facility SOPs. A second CPC (the operator) interpreted that this restriction did not exist.

Analysis

After reviewing the facility SOPs and FAA Order JO 7110.65, the directive that defines U.S. air traffic control procedures and separation standards, the operator examined the variation and concluded that crossing runway separation standards did not include weather restrictions or tower-applied visual separation requirements.

Examination (external to the framework)

Notes: The operator reviewed the relevant sections of the facility SOPs and JO 7110.65 concerning crossing runway separation standards.

Operational Process: An Air Traffic Safety Action Program (ATSAP) report was submitted supporting the operator's interpretation.

Operational Review: The incident initiated a System Service Review (SSR), which confirmed that crossing runway separation standards do not contain weather restrictions or tower-applied visual separation requirements. The facility later received a formal briefing on the matter.

Insight

The misinterpretation extended facility-wide and was partially due to how crossing runway separation standards for IFR aircraft operating in IMC were taught at the facility.

Yield

The facility training department updated its procedures to correct the interpretation of crossing runway separation standards.

Learn

The operator learned that procedural and operational drift can extend to the point where it becomes formalized within a training environment.

Scope

The misinterpretation appeared to be contained at the facility level. However, the operator also observed that JO 7110.65 does not contain specific procedures addressing IMC separation standards between two IFR aircraft during crossing runway operations, while such procedures do exist for same-runway operations, specifically between arrivals and departures. This absence may allow similar misinterpretations to occur at a broader system level.